

159 Cornelius

The Roman officer whose household became the first Gentile home filled with the Holy Ghost.

Cornelius was a Roman centurion stationed at Caesarea. He was not a Jew, but he feared God, prayed constantly, and gave generously to the poor. One afternoon an angel told him to send for Peter in Joppa. Meanwhile God was preparing Peter with a vision of unclean animals and a voice saying, "What God hath cleansed, that call not thou common." When Peter arrived, Cornelius had gathered his relatives and friends. As Peter preached Jesus, the Holy Ghost fell on them all. It was a turning point: God welcomes every nation on the same terms, through faith in Christ.

At a glance

Name	Latin <i>Cornelius</i> , a common Roman family name
Family	"All his house" (Acts 10:2, 24)
Rank	Centurion of "the band called the Italian band" (Acts 10:1)
When	Probably the late AD 30s, before AD 44
Key places	Caesarea; Joppa
Key people	Peter; an angel; the believers from Joppa
Main passages	Acts 10:1–48; 11:1–18; 15:7–9
Known as	First Gentile household shown receiving the Spirit (Acts 10:44–45)

"Of a truth I perceive that God is no respecter of persons: But in every nation he that feareth him, and worketh righteousness, is accepted with him."

Acts 10:34–35, KJV

The life of Cornelius

Acts gives no year. The story comes after Paul's conversion and before Herod Agrippa I's death in AD 44, so it probably happened in the late AD 30s. The timeline follows the days as Acts counts them.

Before the vision <i>Caesarea</i>	● A devout soldier Cornelius is a centurion who fears God with all his household. He gives much alms to the people and prays to God continually. <i>Acts 10:1-2</i>
Day 1 <i>The ninth hour</i>	● An angel appears About three in the afternoon, an angel tells Cornelius that his prayers and alms have come up before God. He is to send to Joppa for Simon Peter. He sends two servants and a soldier. <i>Acts 10:3-8</i>
Day 2 <i>Joppa</i>	● Peter's vision At noon on the rooftop, Peter sees a sheet full of animals, clean and unclean, and hears, "What God hath cleansed, that call not thou common." Cornelius's messengers arrive at the gate. <i>Acts 10:9-23</i>
Day 4 <i>Caesarea</i>	● Peter arrives Cornelius has gathered his relatives and close friends. He falls at Peter's feet, but Peter raises him up, saying, "I myself also am a man." Cornelius explains why he sent for him. <i>Acts 10:24-33</i>
Day 4 <i>Caesarea</i>	● The Spirit falls While Peter is still preaching about Jesus, the Holy Ghost falls on all who hear. The Jewish believers are astonished. Peter orders them to be baptized in the name of the Lord. <i>Acts 10:34-48</i>
Soon after <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Peter explains Some believers criticise Peter for eating with Gentiles. He tells the whole story, and they fall silent and glorify God, saying God has granted the Gentiles "repentance unto life." <i>Acts 11:1-18</i>

Key activities

Some scholars point out that the Italian cohort is known from inscriptions at a slightly later date. Others note that auxiliary units moved often, so this does not create a real difficulty.

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- 1 Feared God with his household.** He led his whole house in the worship of the God of Israel. *Acts 10:2*

 - 2 Gave and prayed.** He "gave much alms to the people, and prayed to God alway." *Acts 10:2*

 - 3 Obeyed at once.** As soon as the angel left, he sent men to Joppa. *Acts 10:7-8*

 - 4 Gathered others to hear.** He called together his relatives and near friends to wait for Peter. *Acts 10:24*

 - 5 Listened with an open heart.** "Now therefore are we all here present before God, to hear all things that are commanded thee of God." *Acts 10:33*

 - 6 Received the Holy Ghost.** "While Peter yet spake these words, the Holy Ghost fell on all them which heard the word." *Acts 10:44*

 - 7 Was baptized.** He and his household were baptized in the name of the Lord and asked Peter to stay on for some days. *Acts 10:47-48*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Cornelius.

Old Testament

Leviticus 11	Clean and unclean animals, behind Peter's vision
Echo: Genesis 12:3	All families of the earth blessed in Abraham
Echo: 2 Kings 5:15	Naaman, a foreign commander, knows Israel's God
Echo: Jonah 1:3; 4:1-2	From Joppa too, Jonah resisted mercy to Gentiles

New Testament

Acts 10:1-48	The main account
Acts 11:1-18	Peter retells the story in Jerusalem
Acts 15:7-9	Peter recalls it at the council
Echo: Matthew 8:5-13	The centurion of Capernaum's great faith
Echo: Galatians 3:28	Neither Jew nor Greek, all one in Christ

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words does Acts use to describe Cornelius before Peter came (Acts 10:1-2, 22)?
2. *Understand:* Cornelius already prayed and gave alms. Why did he still need to hear about Jesus (Acts 10:43; 11:14)?
3. *Apply:* Who could you invite to church, to a meal or to your group this month?
4. *Apply:* Is there a kind of person you tend to avoid? What is one step toward them this week?